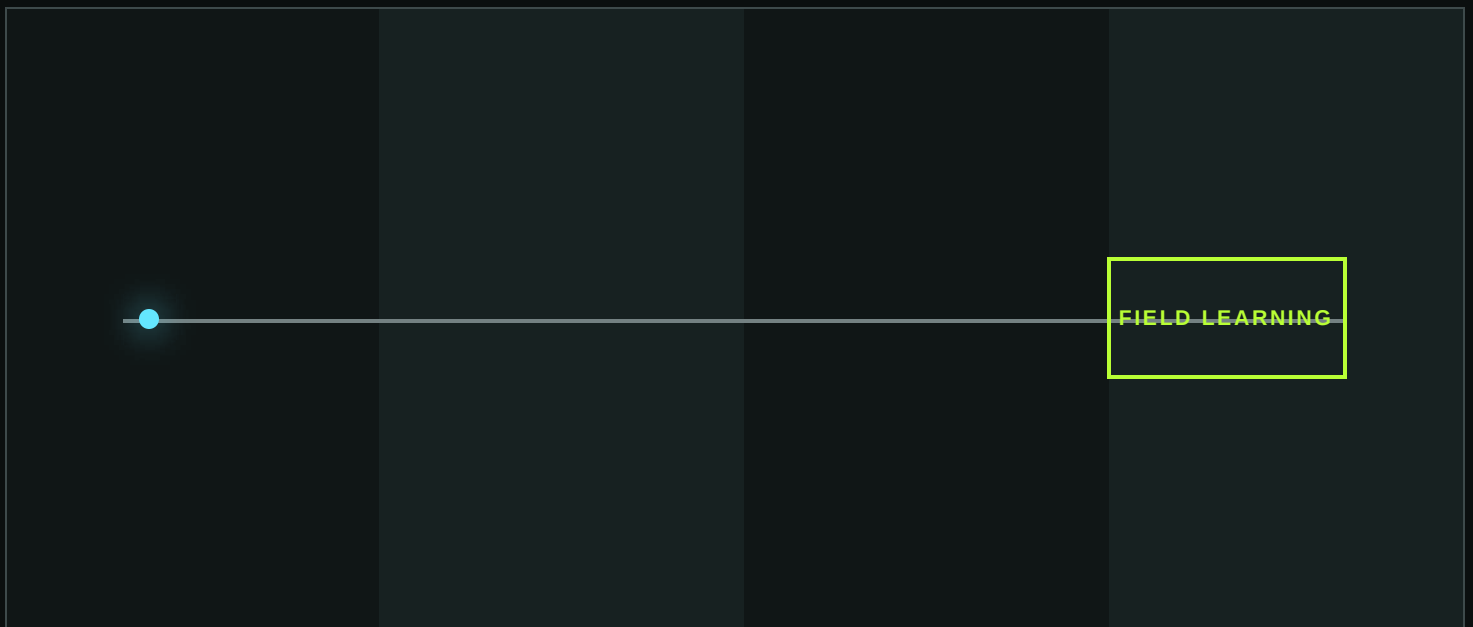




INDEPENDENT CANDIDATE ENTRY
PLAN

120 days to make portfolio decisions earlier, clearer, and more useful.

Product Associate Director (Group Product Manager)
Russell Dudek



Entry principle: tactical empathy before prescription. Read the mission and the existing product system before changing cadence, artifacts, or authority.

Phase I - Read and frame

DAYS 1-30

Build the operating picture

• Listen with CPO, VP Product Management, product engineering, UX, growth, sales, program, support, contracts/acquisition, and mission leaders.

• Review product strategies, roadmaps, backlogs, discovery evidence, release decisions, support trends, deployment patterns, and competitive positioning.

• Map user-access constraints across open, restricted, and classified environments.

• Identify where top-down direction conflicts with bottom-up product evidence.

• Establish a coaching baseline with PMs and UX designers through working sessions, not evaluation theater.

• Inventory current AI-assisted product and engineering practices and where human review remains essential.

Outputs

OUTPUT	PURPOSE
Portfolio decision map	Who decides investment, release, integration, evidence, and escalation
Mission/user access map	How teams discover and validate in constrained environments
Support and integration signal inventory	Recurring work that may justify productization
PM/UX craft baseline	Where coaching and operating friction have highest leverage

DAYS 31-60

Install a minimal shared contract

• Co-create the Mission Window Contract using existing language where possible.

• Select three portfolio hypotheses tied to live product or market decisions.

• Define qualitative scorecard fields and baseline collection.

• Clarify portfolio vs. product-team decision rights.

• Pilot AI-assisted discovery synthesis, backlog hygiene, product requirement critique, test generation, and decision-record drafting with explicit review boundaries.

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Phase II - Prove and institutionalize

DAYS 61-90

Run live Mission Window Reviews

- Use one agentic-orchestration, one information-operations, and one sensor/CBRNE decision as the first review set.
- Make mission outcome, authority, integration burden, evidence, acquisition, and learning return explicit.
- Resolve at least one capacity conflict and one platform-vs-product boundary with named owners and evidence.
- Connect roadmap language with growth positioning, support burden, and engineering dependencies.
- Coach PM and UX leads through the decision work; document what is reusable and what must remain local.

DAYS 91-120

Make learning compound

- Institutionalize a quarterly portfolio review and a lighter monthly evidence cadence.
- Return field, support, deployment, and evaluation evidence into product and platform roadmaps.
- Publish a concise executive roadmap narrative: bets, evidence, dependencies, acquisition path, and stop conditions.
- Establish the next two coaching priorities for PM/UX and the next two AI-assisted tradecraft experiments.
- Retire, merge, or simplify artifacts that do not improve actual decisions.

120-day success evidence

DIMENSION	WHAT SHOULD BE VISIBLY DIFFERENT
Decision clarity	Portfolio and product-team rights are explicit; unresolved conflicts have owners and next evidence.
Roadmap quality	Major bets show mission outcome, proof threshold, acquisition path, integration burden, and learning return.
Team craft	PM and UX leaders demonstrate stronger problem framing, evidence use, and decision communication.
Product economics	Recurring support and deployment work is visible and prioritized for reuse or productization.
AI acceleration	Selected product/engineering practices are faster without hiding human responsibility or quality controls.
Learning speed	Field evidence changes at least one product, platform, or investment decision.

Targets should be set after baselines are established. This plan deliberately avoids fabricated percentages or assumptions about undisclosed internal performance.